dead and wounded over 200. This marked the start of a second *Intifada*; within a month 127 Palestinians had been killed.

The underlying cause of this second *Intifada* was the frustration and anger of the Palestinians in the occupied territories of the West Bank and in Gaza. Seven years after the Oslo peace agreement, little progress had been made in the peace process, especially over the key issues – the borders of a future Palestinian state, the status of Jerusalem, Jewish settlements in the occupied territories and the right of Palestinian refugees to return to Israel. For many, both in Israel and on the West Bank and in Gaza, things had worsened: Palestinian suicide bombings, Israeli reprisals and the building of more Jewish settlements continued. Between 1993 and 2000, there was a 77 per cent increase in the number of Jewish settlers in the occupied territories. The Palestinians, in particular, felt that they were hemmed in:

- In Gaza, which is smaller than the Isle of Wight, there were a million Palestinians, half of them in refugee camps and dependent on UN hand-outs, living in a thin strip of land between the sea and the Israeli border. There were only 6500 Jewish settlers but they and the troops protecting them controlled a third of the land and most of the water supplies.
- On the West Bank and around Jerusalem there were nearly 400,000 Jewish settlers and tens of thousands of troops. There were over two million Palestinians but the Israelis controlled over 70 per cent of the land and had complete control of the water and electricity supplies. The Israelis controlled the main roads and they restricted the movements of the Palestinians with checkpoints, road blocks and night-time curfews.

The Israelis seemed to be consolidating their hold on the land. A more permanent peace and an independent Palestinian state seemed more distant than ever.

The attack on the World Trade Center in New York 2001

On 11 September 2001, four US passenger planes were hijacked and two of them were flown into the twin towers of the World Trade Center building in New York, leading to the deaths of nearly 3000 people. To Americans, these are known as the events of '9/11' after the date on which they occurred. (They are explained more fully on page 148.) From now onwards, Israel frequently portrayed itself as a nation engaged in the 'war on terror', like its US ally. Ariel Sharon is reported to have said: 'Everyone has his own Bin Laden and Arafat is ours.' The Americans were not impressed. Arafat was the first Arab leader to condemn '9/11'. He stressed that the Palestinians' struggle was mainly a political and national struggle whereas Bin Laden's war against the West was a religious one. He also emphasised that Palestinians only used violence in self-defence, in their resistance to Israeli occupation.